

The Instability Itself Is the Institution: Ministerial Survival and Institutional Learning in Peru, 1821–2026

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Abstract

Why do political systems that change so much change so little in how they govern? This paper addresses that question through an original dataset of 1,062 ministerial spells covering five portfolios in Peru from 1821 to 2026. Rather than treating ministerial duration as the outcome to be explained, we treat it as a signal: an observable trace of the continuity conditions under which governing experience either accumulates into institutional knowledge or is repeatedly lost. We organize the analysis around two analytical heuristics. The first is the institutional epoch — the path-dependent period between critical junctures — which captures whether successive historical ruptures produced durable improvements in continuity conditions. The second is the protective belt — a localized architecture of external accountability relationships that, where it exists, insulates certain ministries from the political logic governing the rest of the cabinet. Kaplan–Meier survival curves, log-rank tests, and Cox proportional hazards models show that epochs explain ministerial survival far better than individual traits or portfolio membership, and that continuity conditions did not improve monotonically across two centuries. The largest shift in the data occurred between the Oligarchic State and the Power-Sharing epoch; the most recent democratic period represents a partial regression toward the founding pattern of chronic interruption. The protective belt emerges only after 1993, when external accountability structures raised the cost of Economy minister replacement beyond what domestic political pressure alone could sustain. The central theoretical finding is that chronic ministerial instability in Peru is not evidence of absent institutions but of a durable informal one: the escape valve through which political pressure is absorbed without producing structural change. The instability itself is the institution.

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“Se vogliamo che tutto rimanga
com’è, bisogna che tutto cambi.”

Il Gattopardo
Giuseppe Tomasi di Lampedusa,
1958

Introduction

Governing is hard. Education, health, and public safety are not technical problems with known solutions — they are complex social challenges that resist quick fixes and demand sustained institutional effort. Good policy takes time to design, time to implement, and more time still to reach the people it is meant to serve. Good practices percolate gradually. Organizations learn slowly. Citizens feel change only after years of consistent effort in the same direction. In the big picture, where governance improved, it did so through institutional correction after crisis — converting rupture into consolidation, learning from failure rather than repeating it.

After more than two hundred years of republican life, the Peruvian political class has repeatedly changed governments, cabinets, constitutions, and political coalitions. Yet the underlying pattern remains remarkably stable. Each new administration appoints a cabinet whose members understand, implicitly or explicitly, the terms of their engagement: they are expected to manage complexity on behalf of the leader, but they may also be sacrificed whenever political pressure demands a visible response. Their departure rarely resolves the conflict that triggered it. The resignation of a premier or any other minister may relieve immediate pressure, but it seldom addresses the underlying causes of crisis. Cabinet reshuffles signal responsiveness without necessarily producing institutional correction.

This persistence should not be mistaken for an absence of learning. Political actors adapt continuously. Over time, they have become increasingly adept at navigating constitutional ambiguities, managing blame, and deploying ministerial replacement as a mechanism for absorbing public dissatisfaction. If the political class has learned anything, it has been how to reproduce the system’s response to crisis rather than how to transform it. Governments change. Ministers change. The repertoire through which instability is managed remains largely intact. This cycle has marked much of Peru’s republican history.

This vicious circle is generally called path dependence — a sophisticated way to say that the inertia of accumulated choices makes deviation increasingly costly and increasingly unlikely. And yet paths do break. Oxford philosopher Roman Krznaric (2024) argues that radical change requires what he calls the disruption nexus: a crisis, disruptive movements that amplify it, and powerful ideas that are ready to fill the

space the crisis opens. France's Fifth Republic had all three: the Algerian War as crisis, De Gaulle's movement as disruptive force, and a constitutional design — the strong executive — as the idea ready to be deployed. It was not one event that broke France's path. It was a multigenerational accumulation of chronic instability that the Third and Fourth Republics never resolved. The Fifth Republic became the enduring legacy of a critical juncture in French history. More importantly, it appears to have altered the conditions under which political continuity was produced. The result was not merely institutional change, but a durable shift in the patterns of executive stability that had characterized French politics for more than a century.

France, before the Fifth Republic, was not very different from Peru during the previous hundred years. Both experienced remarkably high levels of executive instability, reflected in similar numbers of premier appointments per decade. Figure 1 tells the story visually. Peru peaked at 23 appointments in the 1890s; France reached 20 in the 1930s. Yet the advent of the Fifth Republic in 1958 initiated sharply diverging trajectories. French premier appointments fell to a stable band of three to six per decade and have remained there ever since, while Peru is returning to levels observed in the nineteenth century. Peru has experienced no shortage of potential disruption nexuses — or, as we will later call them, critical junctures: independence without state-building, the War of the Pacific, hyperinflation, terrorism, the fall of Fujimori, and a permanent constitutional crisis since 2016. Each represented a moment in which alternative institutional trajectories became plausible.

The question, however, is not whether institutional change occurred. Peru's republican history is full of reforms, constitutions, regime transitions, and political ruptures. The question is whether those ruptures altered the conditions under which political experience could be preserved, accumulated, and transmitted over time. From this perspective, a critical juncture is important not simply because it produces a new institutional arrangement, but because it may establish a political legacy capable of reshaping the broader political framework within which governments operate. France appears to have experienced such a transformation after 1958. Peru's trajectory raises the possibility that institutional innovation and the accumulation of political experience do not necessarily coincide.

This paper approaches that question through ministerial duration. Ministerial survival does not measure political experience directly. Rather, it provides observable evidence about the continuity under which political experience may accumulate. Political science has traditionally examined these issues through separate research traditions. Ministerial duration has been studied using survival and event-history analysis, whereas long-term political development has been examined through the comparative-historical literature on critical junctures and path dependence. This paper brings these traditions together by using ministerial duration to evaluate whether successive political frameworks generated different opportunities for the accumulation of political experience.

The analysis is organized around two complementary heuristics. The first

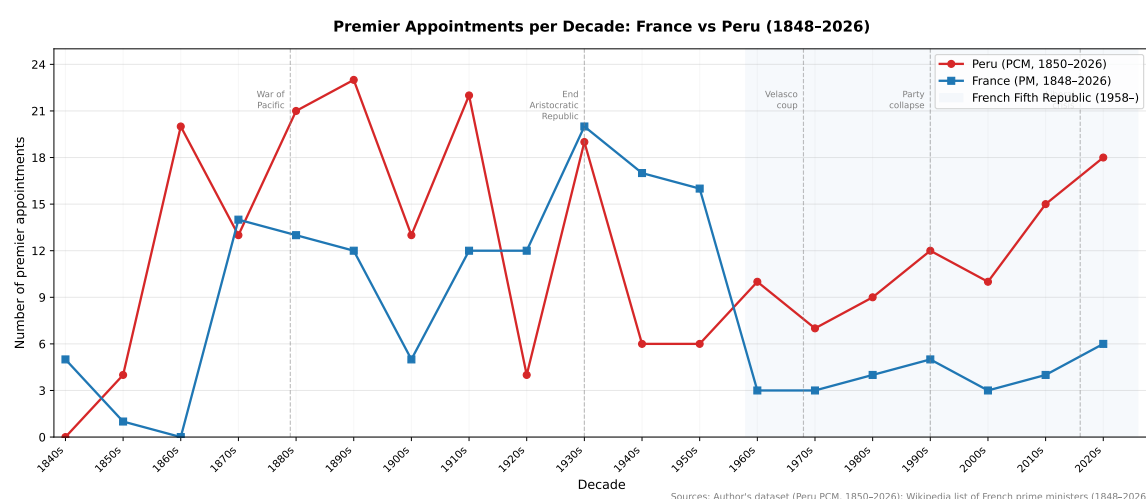


Figure 1

Premier Appointments per Decade: France vs. Peru, 1848–2026.

Sources: Author's dataset (based on Gálvez Montero and García Vega (2016a, 2016b)); Wikipedia list of French prime ministers (1848–2026).

compares patterns of ministerial continuity across historically distinct political frameworks in order to examine how opportunities for knowledge accumulation varied over time. The second compares ministerial continuity across portfolios operating within the same political framework, recognizing that some governmental functions may be institutionally protected from the broader dynamics affecting the rest of the cabinet. Together, these two perspectives distinguish historical variation from organizational variation in the conditions under which political experience accumulates.

The question guiding this study is straightforward: *Have Peru's successive political frameworks generated increasingly favorable opportunities for the accumulation of political experience?*

This question cannot be answered directly. Knowledge accumulation is not directly observable in historical data. Instead, the study approaches the problem indirectly through patterns of ministerial duration. If continuity provides the necessary condition for knowledge accumulation, then systematic differences in ministerial continuity should reveal differences in the opportunities under which political experience accumulates.

The theoretical framework translates this general question into three empirical questions. *First*, what continuity conditions characterized each political framework? *Second*, did those continuity conditions differ systematically across successive political frameworks? *Third*, within the same political framework, do some ministerial portfolios systematically exhibit greater continuity than others?

To answer these questions, we construct an original dataset of individual ministerial spells covering the period from 1821 to 2026. The dataset includes the portfolios

Table 1*Trait-based and Context-based Predictors of Ministerial Survival*

Author(s)	Trait-based	Context-based
Blondel (1988)	Career duration; parliamentary vs. managerial profile	Party system norms; head-of-government style; country context
Huber & Martínez-Gallardo (2008)	Ideological distance from government center; PM party membership; portfolio importance	Coalition type; minority government; electoral volatility; party fractionalization
Dewan & Dowding (2005)	Resignation issue salience; ministerial seniority	PM support level; media attention; single-party vs. coalition system
Fischer et al. (2012)	Age; education; gender; portfolio rank	PM popularity; regime type; frequency of resignation calls
Camerlo & Pérez-Liñán (2015)	Portfolio type; technocrat/partisan/outsider profile; first cabinet appointment	Protests; scandals; electoral calendar; term limits; reelection rules
Camerlo & Castaldo (2024)	Partisan rank within party hierarchy (leader, high-rank, low-rank, newcomer, shadow, defector)	Party government model applicability; regime type; party institutionalization level
Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian (2023)	Technical expertise; presidential group membership; prior electoral experience (<i>risk factor</i>)	Economic growth; GDP per capita; legislative powers; regime type; portfolio area
Mejía et al. (2021)	Education; gender; regional origin; prior elected office	Coalition type; legislative majority; party system change
Alexiadou & Gunaydin (2019)	Technocratic profile; non-partisan status; reform commitment	Economic crisis severity; electoral system type; party control of portfolio
Baturo & Elkink (2014)	Personal traits as time-invariant officeholder effects (education, prior career)	Regime institutionalization; personalization vs. office-based authority
Jara Iñiguez & Cedeño Alcívar (2019)	Managerial performance lifecycle (inverted-U over tenure)	Presidential appointment and dismissal capacity; political trust as selection criterion

most relevant to the argument developed here: the premier, who coordinates the cabinet and sustains the political viability of the executive; the economy minister, whose decisions shape the state’s fiscal and investment capacity; and the ministers of Interior, Health, and Education, whose portfolios address some of the country’s most persistent public challenges according to official yearly surveys (INEI, 2024). The ministerial spells are subsequently organized into historically distinct political frameworks derived from Peru’s critical junctures (Lopez Jimenez et al., 2025). Combining descriptive analysis with survival models, the study evaluates how opportunities for knowledge accumulation varied across political frameworks and across ministerial portfolios.

1 Literature Review

The political science literature on ministerial survival has converged around two broad families of explanations. The first emphasizes the characteristics of ministers themselves. The second emphasizes the political and institutional environments within which ministers operate. Table 1 summarizes the principal covariates identified across the core studies.

1.1 Trait-Based Explanations of Ministerial Survival

Trait-based approaches explain ministerial survival through characteristics of the officeholder. Across different institutional settings, scholars have shown that ministers' professional backgrounds, political careers, partisan affiliations, and personal resources influence their probability of remaining in office. Early studies emphasized broad distinctions between managerial and parliamentary profiles, as well as the effects of career trajectories and prior political experience (Blondel, 1988). Subsequent work expanded the range of relevant characteristics to include age, education, gender, portfolio rank, and seniority within government (Dewan & Dowding, 2005; Fischer et al., 2012).

More recent research has refined these categories by focusing on the organizational and political resources that ministers bring to office. Feliú Ribeiro and López Burian show that technical expertise and membership in presidential networks increase ministerial survival, while prior electoral experience may paradoxically operate as a risk factor (Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian, 2023). Across four Latin American countries between 1945 and 2020, career politicians proved more vulnerable to dismissal than technocrats. The finding suggests that ministerial value cannot be reduced to political experience alone; survival depends on the type of resources that political leaders seek to preserve.

The literature has also moved beyond simple dichotomies between partisan and non-partisan ministers. Camerlo and Castaldo argue that partisan affiliation conceals substantial variation in the strength of a minister's relationship with the party organization. Their framework distinguishes among leaders, high-ranks, low-ranks, newcomers, shadows, and defectors according to levels of engagement, consolidation, and hierarchical position within the party (Camerlo & Castaldo, 2024). Applied to the Argentine cabinet under Alberto Fernández, this approach reveals that apparently strong partisan cabinets may actually consist of ministers with limited organizational leverage over their parties (Camerlo et al., 2024). For survival analysis, the implication is straightforward: ministers classified under the same partisan label may possess very different capacities to resist political pressure.

Taken together, these studies demonstrate that ministerial duration is shaped by who ministers are. Technical expertise, organizational embeddedness, political experience, and personal resources all influence survival prospects. Yet the significance of these traits depends on the environments in which ministers operate. The same characteristic may be rewarded in one institutional setting and penalized in another. This observation leads to the second major family of explanations.

1.2 Context-Based Explanations of Ministerial Survival

Context-based approaches explain ministerial survival through characteristics of the political environment rather than characteristics of individual ministers. In this perspective, ministers survive or fail because of the institutional and political

constraints surrounding them.

The comparative literature consistently identifies coalition dynamics as a central determinant of ministerial duration. Coalition type, minority government status, electoral volatility, and party-system fragmentation all shape the likelihood of ministerial replacement independently of individual characteristics (Huber & Martinez-Gallardo, 2008). Similarly, political crises, scandals, protests, electoral calendars, and term limits alter the incentives presidents face when deciding whether to retain or dismiss ministers (Alexiadou & Gunaydin, 2019; Camerlo & Pérez-Liñán, 2015). Even macroeconomic performance influences survival probabilities by modifying the broader political environment within which governments operate (Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian, 2023).

The case literature illustrates these mechanisms particularly clearly. For Colombia, Mejía Guinand et al. find that individual characteristics matter, but the institutional configuration of the political system ultimately determines the range within which those characteristics can operate (Mejía et al., 2021). Constitutional reforms, changes in party-system structure, and coalition arrangements alter the political logic governing ministerial careers. A similar conclusion emerges from Chile. Avendaño and Dávila show that ministerial turnover during the Concertación governments was driven primarily by coalition management considerations rather than by individual performance. Finance ministers consistently exhibited the longest tenures regardless of personal characteristics (Avendaño & Dávila, 2012).

Recent work has also refined the contextual analysis of ministerial portfolios. Portfolio importance has traditionally been measured through expert rankings that assign ministries a single level of salience. Camerlo and Martínez-Gallardo argue that such measures obscure important differences among ministries, particularly in contexts characterized by weak party institutionalization (Camerlo & Gallardo, 2022). Their framework decomposes ministerial value into policy-management capacity, discretionary resource allocation, political agenda influence, and inter-portfolio coordination authority. Different political environments activate different dimensions of portfolio value, producing distinct survival incentives for presidents and ministers alike.

Taken together, these studies show that ministerial survival depends not only on who ministers are but also on where they operate. Institutional structures, coalition arrangements, political crises, economic conditions, and portfolio characteristics shape the opportunities and constraints governing ministerial careers.

1.3 Reinterpreting Ministerial Duration

The two families of explanations are not competing research programs. Virtually every study combines individual and contextual covariates, with political environments conditioning the effects of ministerial traits. The resulting literature has generated a rich understanding of why some ministers survive longer than others.

What the literature has not asked is a prior question: what do patterns of ministerial survival reveal about the conditions under which political experience is collectively preserved, accumulated, and transmitted over time? Existing studies treat ministerial duration as the outcome to be explained. This paper instead treats ministerial duration as evidence about continuity. Rather than asking why one minister survives longer than another, it asks what patterns of ministerial continuity reveal about the political environments within which knowledge may accumulate.

The next section develops a deductive theoretical framework. It begins by establishing continuity as the necessary condition for knowledge accumulation. It then explains why opportunities for knowledge accumulation vary across political frameworks and why continuity may also vary across ministerial portfolios operating within the same political framework. Together, these propositions provide the conceptual foundation for interpreting ministerial duration as evidence about the historical and organizational conditions under which political experience accumulates.

2 Theoretical Framework

The theoretical framework developed in this paper is organized deductively. It begins by establishing an axiom defining the conditions under which political knowledge may accumulate. From this axiom, two propositions specify the historical and organizational contexts in which continuity conditions vary. Proposition 1 explains variation in continuity conditions across institutional epochs, while Proposition 2 explains variation in continuity conditions across ministerial portfolios within institutional epochs. Together, the axiom and propositions establish the conceptual vocabulary, logical structure, and empirical interpretation used throughout the remainder of the paper.

Throughout the discussion, arrows ($\rightarrow$) are used as heuristic representations of hypothesized causal influence. They indicate a proposed direction of influence rather than a specific sign, magnitude, or deterministic effect.

2.1 Axiom A1: Knowledge Accumulation Requires Continuity

The literature reviewed above treats ministerial survival as the outcome to be explained. Most studies seek to account for variation in survival across individual appointments by focusing on ministers' personal characteristics, political context, or the interaction between the two. This paper adopts a different perspective. Rather than explaining why some ministers survive longer than others, it asks what patterns of ministerial survival reveal about the continuity conditions characterizing a particular institutional order.

The starting point is the observation that ministerial duration is not politically important in itself. What duration provides is time. Time allows experience to be retained, shared, and embedded within organizations rather than repeatedly lost

through replacement. From this perspective, ministerial survival becomes relevant because it provides information about continuity.

Continuity, in turn, points toward a broader question: whether political systems create conditions under which experience can accumulate and be transmitted over time. A central insight of organizational learning theory is that institutions benefit from experience only when that experience can be retained and incorporated into future action (Levitt & March, 1988). Continuity is therefore a necessary condition for processes through which knowledge may accumulate within organizations.

For the purposes of this study, the central concept is **knowledge accumulation**, understood as the retention, articulation, and transmission of experience within organizations. Ministerial duration is not treated as a direct measure of knowledge accumulation itself. Rather, it is interpreted as an observable indicator of the continuity conditions under which knowledge accumulation becomes more or less likely.

The deductive structure of the theoretical framework begins with Axiom A1:

$$\text{Continuity} \rightarrow \text{Knowledge Accumulation} \quad (\text{A1})$$

Axiom A1 states that political knowledge can accumulate only under conditions of continuity. Continuity does not guarantee that knowledge will accumulate, nor does it determine the quality of the knowledge ultimately produced. Rather, it establishes the necessary organizational condition under which experience may be retained, articulated, transmitted, and eventually embedded within institutional routines. Without continuity, opportunities for knowledge accumulation are repeatedly interrupted before experience can become embedded within organizational practice.

Having established continuity as the necessary condition for knowledge accumulation, the next theoretical task is to explain why this relationship holds. Why should continuity matter for the accumulation of political knowledge? The literature provides two complementary answers. The first emerges from organizational theories of knowledge management, which explain how organizations create, retain, and transmit knowledge. The second emerges from theories of public policy and political decision-making, which explain why effective governance itself requires continuity over time. Although these traditions developed largely independently, both converge on the same conclusion embodied in Axiom A1.

The first tradition is represented by the organizational learning literature. Nonaka's theory of organizational knowledge creation conceives knowledge creation as a cumulative process through which tacit knowledge becomes explicit, is shared within the organization, and is eventually internalized into routines and practices (Nonaka, 1998). New knowledge emerges through repeated interaction among organizational members, the articulation of experience into formal procedures, and the gradual incorporation of those procedures into everyday organizational behavior. This process cannot be compressed into a single decision, nor can it survive repeated interruptions without loss. Continuity therefore provides the temporal condition under which organizational knowledge can progressively accumulate.

Cohen, March, and Olsen reinforce this conclusion from a different perspective. Their theory of *organized anarchy* characterizes organizations by problematic preferences, unclear technology, and *fluid participation* (Cohen et al., 1972). Applied to cabinet politics, fluid participation resembles the absence of continuity: decision-makers are replaced before they can develop a shared understanding of the problems they were appointed to address. Under such conditions, the organizational environment required for retaining, articulating, and transmitting experience becomes difficult to sustain. The organizational learning tradition therefore converges on the conclusion that continuity is a prerequisite for sustained knowledge accumulation.

A second line of support emerges from theories of public policy and political decision-making. Simon's theory of bounded rationality argues that complex policy challenges initially present themselves as *ill-structured problems* rather than as clearly defined decision tasks. Because decision-makers operate under conditions of bounded rationality, effective problem solving requires a sequential process in which problems are progressively structured through the identification of relevant constraints, the decomposition of complexity into manageable subproblems, and the gradual refinement of alternative courses of action (Foss & Foss, 2005, pp. 4–5). Each stage of problem solving provides the foundation upon which subsequent stages can proceed, making organizational progress dependent on sustained engagement over time rather than isolated decisions (Foss & Foss, 2005, pp. 12–17). Premature ministerial replacement interrupts this cumulative process before problems become sufficiently structured for effective organizational action.

Lindblom reaches a similar conclusion from the perspective of incremental policymaking. Because policymakers cannot fully specify objectives, evaluate every alternative, or anticipate all consequences, policy develops through successive limited comparisons that build upon previous decisions rather than through comprehensive optimization (Lindblom, 1959). Governing therefore depends on the cumulative experience generated through repeated rounds of adjustment, making continuity a prerequisite for coherent policy development.

Finally, Allison's three conceptual models independently reinforce Axiom A1. Under the rational actor model, continuity allows decision-makers to accumulate information and refine choices under uncertainty. Under the organizational process model, continuity enables experience to become embedded in routines and standard operating procedures (Allison, 1969). Under the governmental politics model, continuity preserves the bargaining relationships, political capital, and mutual expectations required for coordinated action among political actors. Although these three models were developed to explain governmental decision-making from different analytical perspectives, both identify continuity as the organizational condition under which experience becomes cumulative rather than episodic.

Taken together, these two theoretical traditions converge on the same foundational conclusion despite approaching the problem from different directions. The organizational learning literature explains how knowledge is created, retained, and

transmitted within organizations. The public policy literature explains why effective governing requires sustained engagement with complex problems, incremental adjustment, organizational routines, and durable political relationships. Although developed independently, both traditions ultimately support the same foundational principle embodied in Axiom A1: knowledge accumulation requires continuity.

2.2 Proposition 1: Political Frameworks Shape Opportunities for Knowledge Accumulation

Axiom A1 established that knowledge accumulation requires continuity. Proposition 1 addresses a different question. If continuity enables knowledge accumulation, why should opportunities for knowledge accumulation differ across history? More specifically, why should one political framework generate different opportunities for knowledge accumulation than another? Answering this question requires moving beyond organizational processes to the broader political environments within which governments operate.

The central concept proposed here is the **political framework**. A political framework refers to a configuration of political institutions, governing arrangements, and actor relationships that structures political action during a particular historical period. Political frameworks define the broader political environment within which governments operate. Because successive political frameworks need not reproduce the same political conditions, they may also generate different opportunities for knowledge accumulation.

The concept of political framework is grounded in the Critical Juncture tradition of comparative-historical analysis. Rather than viewing political development as a continuous sequence of incremental change, this tradition conceives history as a succession of distinct political orders separated by episodes of rapid institutional transformation—critical junctures. Critical junctures generate enduring political legacies that persist through path-dependent reproduction. These legacies define historically distinct political frameworks within which political actors govern until a subsequent critical juncture establishes a different historical legacy (Capoccia & Kelemen, 2007; Collier & Munck, 2022).

Political Framework $\rightarrow$ Knowledge Accumulation (P1)

Proposition P1 states that political frameworks shape opportunities for knowledge accumulation. The proposition does not modify Axiom A1; rather, it specifies the historical context within which the axiom operates. Because knowledge accumulation requires continuity, differences between successive political frameworks become theoretically important insofar as they facilitate, constrain, or repeatedly interrupt the continuity conditions that make knowledge accumulation possible.

An important implication follows. Institutional innovation should not automatically be interpreted as an improvement in opportunities for knowledge accumu-

lation. Political systems may enact new constitutions, administrative reforms, or governing arrangements without fundamentally altering the conditions under which organizations accumulate experience. Conversely, successive political frameworks that differ substantially in their formal institutional architecture may nevertheless generate similar opportunities for knowledge accumulation. The relevant theoretical question is therefore not whether institutions change, but whether transitions from one political framework to another systematically alter the opportunities for knowledge accumulation.

This proposition provides the basis for defining **institutional learning**. Institutional learning is conceptualized here as a historical property rather than an organizational one. Because knowledge accumulation cannot be observed directly across political frameworks, institutional learning is inferred from historical differences in the opportunities for knowledge accumulation generated by successive political frameworks. Proposition P1 therefore establishes the historical dimension of the theoretical framework by linking transitions between political frameworks to changes in opportunities for knowledge accumulation.

2.3 Proposition 2: Protective Belts Preserve Continuity Within Political Frameworks

Proposition 1 established that opportunities for knowledge accumulation vary across political frameworks. Proposition 2 addresses a different source of variation. Even within the same political framework, continuity is not necessarily distributed uniformly across ministerial portfolios. Some ministries exhibit greater continuity than others despite operating under the same historical and political environment. Explaining this within-framework variation requires an additional organizational mechanism.

The concept proposed here is the **protective belt**¹. A protective belt consists of institutional arrangements that increase the political cost of ministerial replacement, thereby making continuity more likely within a particular ministerial portfolio.

Protective Belt $\rightarrow$ Continuity (P2)

Proposition P2 complements rather than modifies Axiom A1. Whereas Axiom A1 establishes continuity as the necessary condition for knowledge accumulation, Proposition 2 explains why continuity itself may vary across organizations operating under the same political framework. Protective belts therefore provide a localized organizational mechanism through which continuity can be preserved despite the broader political environment.

Comparative evidence suggests that such protective arrangements emerge under particular patterns of political accountability. Feliú Ribeiro and López Burian

¹The term “protective belt” is borrowed from Lakatos’s philosophy of science, where it refers to the set of auxiliary assumptions that shields the hard core of a research programme from immediate falsification (Lakatos, 1978). The concept is used here metaphorically to denote institutional arrangements that shield ministerial continuity from political pressures.

show that foreign affairs portfolios survive significantly longer than domestic portfolios across Latin America (Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian, 2023). They argue that foreign ministers become accountable not only to domestic political actors but also to international audiences, increasing the political costs of replacement and thereby making continuity more likely. Their findings illustrate how portfolio-specific institutional arrangements can produce different continuity patterns within the same political framework.

Protective belts are not expected to remain attached to the same ministerial portfolios over time. Because critical junctures reshape political legacies and redefine the priorities of successive political frameworks, the portfolios requiring greater continuity may also change. Protective belts therefore constitute organizational adaptations operating within political frameworks rather than permanent characteristics of particular ministries.

Proposition P2 establishes the organizational dimension of the theoretical framework. Whereas Proposition 1 explains why opportunities for knowledge accumulation vary across political frameworks, Proposition 2 explains why continuity varies across ministerial portfolios operating within the same political framework. Together, the two propositions specify the historical and organizational contexts within which Axiom A1 operates.

3 Research Design and Analytical Strategy

The theoretical framework established three complementary statements. Axiom A1 identifies continuity as the necessary organizational condition for knowledge accumulation. Proposition P1 explains why opportunities for knowledge accumulation may vary across political frameworks, while Proposition P2 explains why continuity may also vary across ministerial portfolios operating within the same political framework.

The purpose of the research design is not to observe these theoretical constructs directly. Knowledge accumulation, political frameworks, and protective belts are latent concepts rather than observable variables. Instead, the research design derives observable implications from the theoretical framework and specifies how empirical patterns should be interpreted. Ministerial duration constitutes the principal observable quantity throughout the analysis and serves as the empirical basis from which continuity is inferred.

The analytical strategy therefore proceeds in three stages. First, the theoretical concepts are operationalized heuristically. Second, the observable implications of Propositions P1 and P2 are evaluated statistically. Third, the resulting empirical patterns are interpreted using historically grounded heuristics derived from the Critical Juncture tradition.

3.1 Heuristic Operationalization

The theoretical concepts introduced in the previous section cannot be measured directly. Rather than treating them as directly observable variables, this study establishes theoretically justified correspondences between abstract concepts and empirical observations. These heuristic operationalizations do not claim to measure the theoretical constructs themselves; instead, they provide the interpretive bridge through which the propositions can be evaluated empirically.

3.1.1 *Political Frameworks*

Political frameworks constitute the historical units through which Proposition P1 is evaluated. Because political frameworks are theoretical constructs rather than directly observable entities, they require heuristic operationalization.

Following the Critical Juncture tradition of comparative-historical analysis, political frameworks are operationalized through the enduring political legacies generated by completed critical junctures. Rather than partitioning history according to arbitrary chronological periods, presidential administrations, or constitutional reforms, this operationalization identifies relatively stable political environments bounded by critical junctures whose legacies redefine the conditions under which political actors govern.

Table 2 summarizes the political frameworks employed throughout the analysis. Each framework corresponds to the dominant political legacy established by a completed critical juncture and extends until a subsequent critical juncture generates a different historical legacy. The chronology follows Lopez Jimenez et al. (2025) and provides complete coverage of Peru’s republican period while preserving the historically meaningful political environments required for evaluating Proposition P1.

3.1.2 *Continuity*

Continuity constitutes the central observable implication of the theoretical framework. It is not measured directly. Instead, continuity is inferred heuristically from ministerial duration.

Following Axiom A1, longer ministerial spells indicate greater opportunities for organizational continuity, whereas shorter spells indicate more frequent interruption of governing experience. Ministerial duration is therefore interpreted neither as a measure of ministerial quality, political effectiveness, nor policy success, but as evidence concerning the continuity conditions under which knowledge accumulation becomes more or less feasible.

This interpretation does not imply that continuity is the only determinant of ministerial duration. Individual characteristics, political crises, presidential strategies, coalition dynamics, and other contextual factors may also influence ministerial survival. Rather, Axiom A1 identifies continuity as the theoretical dimension of ministerial duration that is relevant for evaluating the propositions developed in this

Table 2*Political Frameworks Used in the Analysis*

Political Framework	Period	Originating Critical Juncture	Dominant Political Legacy
PF1 – State Formation	1824–1883	Independence (1810–1824)	Failed national state-building; persistent caudillo politics; colonial institutional continuities.
PF2 – Oligarchic State	1883–1933	War of the Pacific (1879–1883)	Elite reconstruction under oligarchic rule; patrimonial state consolidation and restricted political incorporation.
PF3 – Power-Sharing State	1933–1975	Crisis of the Aristocratic Republic (1920–1933)	Tripartite political order involving oligarchy, APRA, and the armed forces; gradual incorporation of organized social actors.
PF4 – Democratic Transition and Crisis	1975–1993	Military Revolution (1968–1975)	Democratization following military rule under conditions of economic collapse, political violence, and institutional crisis.
PF5 – Democracy without Parties	1993–2022	Fujimori Settlement (1982–1992)	Neoliberal political order characterized by weak parties, electoral volatility, and sustained executive predominance.

Note: Political frameworks constitute heuristic operationalizations of the enduring political legacies generated by completed critical junctures. They provide the historical units employed throughout the empirical analyses. Adapted from Lopez Jimenez et al. (2025).

paper.

3.1.3 Protective Belts

Protective belts likewise remain unobservable. Their existence is inferred indirectly from systematic differences in continuity across ministerial portfolios operating within the same political framework.

Observed differences in continuity do not constitute direct evidence of protective belts. Rather, they represent empirical patterns that are consistent with the existence of institutional arrangements capable of shielding particular portfolios from the political pressures affecting ministerial turnover.

3.2 Analytical Strategy

The empirical implications of the propositions are evaluated through two complementary comparisons.

The first comparison evaluates Proposition P1. Because political frameworks represent successive historical environments, the relevant empirical implication concerns changes in continuity associated with transitions between political frameworks,

$$\Delta PF_{i,i+1} \longrightarrow \Delta C_{i,i+1}.$$